

Proven Vengeance

The best way to sum up the character of Nadine Coyle is that she missed her calling - because MMA doesn't afford her the opportunity to play the heel the way she wants to.

She does the best she can, though. Her arena entrances and exits are even more direct than Emily's, but it has nothing to do with focus or humility. It is also not an act. She simply doesn't care about people. Not her fans, and certainly not her opponents. So she marches to the cage with an air like humanity itself was beneath her, and having to deal with people actually makes her angry.

It's an aggravation she's willing to put up with, simply because of the fun she gets to have once the cage door closes. She's proven many times that she has a very high tolerance for damage, and she's extremely proud of it. There's nothing she enjoys more than standing in the center of the cage and trading punches with an opponent in a contest of toughness and will. Contests she wins far more often than not.

Winning, of course, doesn't make her a heel. But the way she goes about it definitely does. She doesn't just defeat her opponents. She destroys them. There are many - myself included - who believe she really enjoys it... to the point where I think she'd prefer the ref not be around to stop her.

Hard evidence for this theory is not easy to come by. She has never said anything like, *I like it when my opponents bleed* or *I really enjoy breaking bones*. In fact, her press conferences are generally short - both in length and in substance. But the style in which she fights tells a story of its own. Experts often talk about a fighter's *killer instinct*. That ability to know when an opponent is wounded and put her away before she can recover. In Coyle's case, she only seems to complete half of the recipe. She certainly seems to recognize when her opponent is hurt, but that knowledge seems to slow her pace, rather than accelerate it. She doesn't go for the finish. Instead, she tends to back off and then start methodically taking her wounded prey apart. Choosing to pound on a disoriented challenger instead of going for the knockout.

Competing theories do exist. Perhaps Nadine is just more cautious. Choosing to play it safe and keep her adversary pinned down with a consistent barrage instead of opening herself up a bit to go for the finale. But I don't buy it for a second. It's happened too many times. Too many fights where she seemed to be carrying her opponent, just so she could continue the beating. I've also found that too many people I know and trust agree with me.

It's also worth noting that the theory is not limited to insiders. Pundits have publicly questioned whether or not Nadine has a serious dark streak, only to be rebuffed by her supporters. They argue that she's just doing what she's supposed to do. That it's a fight, and hurting each other is the goal. If her opponents don't like it, they should become better fighters and stop her.

That last point is where the conversation gets hung up. Because isn't that the very essence of the sport?

At the most basic level, the answer is yes. But Nadine takes things too far too often, and I believe her results bear that out. With sixty-seven wins to go with only twelve losses, her dominance cannot be questioned. She is an undeniably great fighter. But break down those wins, and you find something deeply disturbing. Twenty-six of them have come by way of knockout, one by

submission and ten by decision. A deeper inspection of her knockout total reveals that only seven were true knockouts. The other nineteen were *technical* knockouts - situations where the ref felt the need to stop the fight to protect Nadine's opponent from severe and possibly permanent injury.

By itself, that doesn't mean much. Referees often step in to stop a bout before a true knockout is achieved. But to have nearly seventy-five percent of your knockouts come by way of stoppage is more than a little suspicious. If your opponent is that hurt, then you likely had chances to put her away. Chances you didn't take.

But the most damning statistic comes from the final category: injury. Thirty times, Nadine was declared the winner because the ringside doctor stopped the fight between rounds by declaring her opponent medically unfit to continue.

Now, look... injuries happen. But to win roughly half your fights that way is unheard of.

Fact is, I don't need any of these numbers to convince me. I've crossed paths with fighters like Nadine in my past, and the truth is right there in their eyes. You can see the hunger. Fighting is not just a competition to them. Winning isn't enough. Hurting people gives them pleasure.

Isa calls them *las salvajes*. The savages. Quite a damning remark for one fighter to make about another in the brutal, illegal world of underground fighting. Which tells you exactly what we thought of them.

We had ways of dealing with those people. In a world where rules were scarce, self-policing was a necessity. And make no mistake... there is a part of me that would love to get in the cage and teach Nadine a lesson. Though I've never been a particularly sadistic fighter, I think I would very much enjoy hurting her. But those tactics are not permitted here. Instead, I have to be satisfied with knowing that RSI has helped make Tiffany immune. She is no longer Nadine's plaything... a fact I believe drives Coyle crazy. It is one of the accomplishments I'm most proud of... but I still wouldn't say I'm satisfied.

I don't think about it much. I have more important things to do. But right this very second - as Coyle settled into her corner and Emma's music spun up - it bothered me a lot.

Emma's taste in music is so eclectic, I had no idea how she would settle on a walkout song. One day Whitney Houston. Next day Tom Petty. Lady Gaga, a little Britney and Wyclef Jean. Then swim back in time for Paul Simon, Tina Turner, Joni Mitchell and Nat King Cole.

One day I found her taking a break with her ear buds in. I asked what she was listening to, and she said it was *Nocturne in C# Minor* by Frédéric Chopin.

I just nodded my head and kept walking because what the fuck do you say to something like that?

Eventually the others had to get involved, and a push was made for Kelly Clarkson's *Stronger*. It seemed a good choice to me, but Emma nixed it. My guess? Too obvious. However, the attempt did get her looking Clarkson's way, and she eventually settled on a lesser-known song called *Miss Independent*.

Title? Excellent. Content? All wrong... but since when does Emma care? The song picks up at the chorus when she makes her entrance, and I gotta say... it rocks.

As she strode in tonight, I couldn't tell how much of what I was seeing was real and how much was in my head. Emma was a rare breed who took the time to really enjoy her fans. Most fighters do it like Emily. Eyes on the prize. Fun time comes later. But Emma can't seem to hold it back, and she's generally willing to break her focus for a bit to acknowledge the crowd. Not whooping it up like a fool, but a little more interaction. Higher wattage smiles and a few high fives along the way. The prototypical face. The perfect foil to Coyle's darkness.

Only there was none of that tonight. Her entrance was a steady, blinders-on march to the cage. A woman on a mission.

I didn't like it at all.

There was no precedent to lean on for this fight because Coyle's name is prominent on the list of top tier featherweights that Emma has yet to face. There's no particular reason for that. Fate just hadn't brought them together until now. Still, it was a glaring omission as far as Emma's record went. If she wanted to be considered top tier herself, she needed this win. She could not afford to be distracted.

Complicating matters further was the fact that the referee for this one was Nikki Sanderson. Not that Sanderson was bad. She's mostly known as a fighter's ref. Unless a rule is broken or one of the fighters is clearly incapacitated, she tends to stay out of the way and let the women fight. Normally a good thing... except here it also meant she would give Coyle plenty of opportunity to abuse Emma if this started to go the wrong way.

Logic dictated that there was no reason to worry. Though the experts might not be willing to count her among the elite, I knew how good a fighter Emma was. As good as Tiff, and easily as good as Nadine. And with the way she'd been fighting in this tournament... if Coyle tried to get cute, I was confident Em could make her pay.

The problem is that logic isn't everything in a fight. As Liv had so thoroughly demonstrated, emotion can play a big role if you let it. That wasn't normally an issue for Emma. She's very used to suffering whatever slings and arrows the world sends her way with barely a flinch. But Coyle wasn't business as usual. This was personal. Because if there's one surefire way to draw a reaction from Em, it's to go after her friends. Did she feel Tiff's resurgence had righted the wrongs Nadine had done, or was she like me... dissatisfied? Would that make getting this win even more important to her? Would she take her eye off the ball in the process of trying to get it?

As these questions swam through my head, I realized I had precious few answers. I think I know Emma pretty well, but the things I knew best about her came down on opposite sides of the fence this time. She was thorough, skilled and smart. Too smart to let her emotions control her. But she was also loyal to a fault, and I couldn't shake the idea that she might want this one a little too much.

The team climbed into the cage, and I kept my eyes on Steph. Looking for signs she was seeing what I was. But I didn't notice anything different about the way she handled the last minute strategy discussion. So maybe I was crazy.

Then Sanderson called the fighters out for final instructions, and I was seeing things again.

Emma's expression was impassive. No smirk. No anger. She was a blank slate. But her eyes never left Coyle's face. Not even for a second.

Coyle answered with a dismissive sneer. A show, I was sure. Even she wasn't arrogant enough to take Emma lightly. But the scene had an undeniable tension to it. Coyle looked like she was right on the edge of saying something... and I got the sense that Emma was just dying for her to say it.

My fears went unrealized, and I was once again left to wonder if I was making all of this up.

Then the action got started, and I pushed my questions aside. One way or the other, I would have the answers soon.

I have to give Nadine credit... her opening move was one I don't think anyone would have expected. No warm up. No feeling out. She got her feet planted and just unloaded the right hand... right into Emma's face.

It happened so fast, I really didn't grasp what I'd seen. It wasn't until I saw the replay later that I appreciated the ferocity of the blow. The kind of thing that had *one punch knockout* written all over it. Emma hadn't expected it, didn't react quickly enough and ended up taking the full force of it nearly dead center.

What came next probably had a lot to do with why I was confused. Because Emma didn't do her part to sell it. She didn't stumble or try to regroup. She didn't even move. She just fired back with a flurry of her own. Like she didn't even feel it. Coyle responded in kind, and there was suddenly a full-on brawl in the middle of the cage. A brawl that Emma seemed to be winning... but only briefly.

Coyle slid right to get clear of the fray. Emma moved to follow... and walked right into a savage uppercut that landed right on the point of her chin.

Again we were in a situation where Emma should have been seeing stars. That's what Nadine expected, and she ran to capitalize... only to be met by a bone-breaking right hand from the RSI fighter.

Coyle retreated a step, then came right back for more. Emma turned into a low kick. Nadine took it harmlessly on her thigh, but Emma reset quickly and launched a body kick with the same leg. Coyle had her guard up high, and Emma's foot slid cleanly under it. Nadine had no choice but to move because the kick literally knocked her sideways. Still, she staggered only a step or two before wading back into the battle.

The two squared up and started throwing - Nadine landing ANOTHER uppercut while Emma connected with the cross.

A quick reset, then Nadine came forward again. Emma came with another kick, about waist high. Coyle saw it and blocked... but Emma changed levels and scored a brutal shot to the head.

Still, Nadine came right back. There was another wild exchange of punches, with both fighters taking a fair amount of damage. Then both finally retreated for a bit of a breather.

This was nuts. Just over a minute in, bombs were landing all over the place, and all I could think was, *Hey! Anybody wanna play defense down there?*

The brief intermission allowed me a good look at Em. Her eyes seemed clear and her movement was good. A little blood seeped from the corner of her mouth. If that was the worst of the damage after taking two knockout-worthy punches from a fighter like Nadine... well I was OK with that. Meanwhile, though Coyle was largely unmarked, I expected to see some bruising from those kicks any moment now.

Overall, I was left with the feeling that something bad was going on. This was starting to feel like some sort of ass-backward toughwoman contest, with the fighters challenging themselves to endure each other's best shots to see which one could take it better.

And they were far from finished.

The two met again near the center of the cage. This time, it was Emma that made the first move. Another body kick slid in under Coyle's guard as the block came too late.

Another wild exchange followed. Emma got her licks in, but Coyle connected more solidly and seemed to come out the winner.

How were these two withstanding this? And why was Emma playing into Nadine's hands by fighting her straight on like this?

The ladies went right back to it... and Emma struck AGAIN with the kick. This time she tried to follow with a monstrous hook, but Nadine stepped back out of range.

They lined up and there was another crazy exchange with Coyle out boxing Em and forcing her to retreat.

It was the first time Coyle had gotten Em to back up, and she immediately moved forward to press her advantage. Em threw out another kick to slow her down, but Coyle kept on coming... jabbing her way in, then launching a shovel hook with the same hand. The punch is thrown much like an uppercut... with the fighter's weight on her front foot. The difference is the the angle. Not straight up like an uppercut or horizontal like a hook, but nearly dead in-between. Like she was throwing a shovel full of dirt over her shoulder. An apt description, as the punch dug around Emma's guard and found rib meat. I winced involuntarily, knowing from personal experience that she felt that one deep inside.

Coyle kept the pressure on with aggressive combinations. Then, just when it looked like she was going to push the action up against the fence... Em popped the teep.

Even from way up here I could tell it wasn't as clean and sharp as Emily's version, but it got the job done as it knocked Coyle away and halted her progress.

A minute and a half to go. Time for one of them to put her stamp on this round.

Nadine pressed forward behind a flurry of punches. Emma answered with a salvo of her own, but neither really found much contact.

Coyle tried again... launching a brilliant combination to the body, then finishing with a wicked right hand that found Emma's cheek. It hurt me just to watch.

Nadine pushed forward with another combo. Emma retreated and circled away, then launched another body kick. Coyle leaned out of range and let the kick sail by, then surged in and punished Watson with another series of punches to the body.

One minute to go, and I didn't like this at all. For reasons I couldn't fathom, Emma was still doing things Nadine's way. Now the round was slipping away, and she was taking real damage in the process. She needed to stop this craziness and turn this thing around right now.

Em apparently received my psychic vibrations, and gave me half of what I asked for.

Coyle came again behind her jab, then went back to the shovel hook. Emma was ready this time... getting her elbow down and stepping into a right-handed hook of her own. Coyle's punch went nowhere while Emma's connected beautifully. Nadine's head came up, and Em's punch instantly slammed it sideways. And she must have had a sense she was going to find pay dirt because there was no wait-and-see as she decided what to do next. She was in full attack mode the second the punch landed. Non-stop combinations and great footwork kept her in position as she hammered Coyle across the cage. Nadine tried to cover up and jab her way out of it, but the punches were nothing more than a nuisance to Emma.

Twenty seconds to go. Nadine tightened her guard up high to protect her head, but Emma was processing things like a machine. Guard goes up, punches go down. She didn't even break rhythm. Just lowered her aim and pounded her fists into Coyle's gut. Nadine tried to grapple and tie things up. Emma pushed her off and kept up the assault. The ten-second clacker sounded. Nadine brought her leg up to try to push her tormentor away. Emma stepped inside of it, and unleashed an uppercut that almost put Coyle into orbit. Nadine slumped back against the cage... and the bell sounded to end the round.

Sanderson started forward to check on Coyle, but the Irishwoman quickly proved she still had her senses as she bounced off the mesh and shoved Emma away in disgust. Emma went right back at her, getting right in Nadine's face. Disrespect isn't something Coyle takes well, and I half-expected her to take a swing... a reaction I suspected Emma wouldn't mind, at all. Sanderson jumped in and separated the two brawlers before things got out of control, ordering them back to their respective corners. Coyle said something as she turned to go, but Emma just looked her off before heading toward the rest of the RSI team.

At that point, I was sure of two things. The first was that Emma was definitely taking this one personally. The second... there was no way this fight was going the distance.

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Everything was normal in the RSI corner during the break. Marcy had a little blood and some swelling to control, but Emma was in remarkably good shape given how crazy the round had been. Steph was matter of fact as she talked things over with her fighter. She probably wasn't too thrilled with the number of heavy blows Em had taken, but Coyle had paid an even higher price. On balance, it had been a good round... one I scored firmly for Emma. While she had almost let it get away, I was convinced she'd stolen it back with that vicious offensive outburst at the end.

As for me... I didn't know what to think about what I'd just seen. Emma is a very strategic fighter, so I didn't understand why she'd elected to go toe-to-toe with Coyle and just pound it out. But I also

had to give her credit... she had done it well. Though it had not been pretty, she'd beaten Nadine at her own game.

Still... it seemed to me there were much better ways for her to go about things, and I was hoping for a more discrete approach in round two.

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I did not get my wish. At least, not right away.

The round started off with the two of them going right back to the same crazy slugging in the center of the cage. Both weaving and swaying as they swung back and forth at each other. Most of the punches were harmless, until Emma landed a strong one-two that forced Coyle to retreat.

Nadine got her bearings and waded back in, and the cycle repeated itself almost exactly. A mad rush of punches from both sides until Emma connected solidly enough to make her opponent back up again.

Clearly having had enough, Coyle came back like a bull... pushing forward behind a stiff jab and a high guard. Emma got in a couple of body shots before Coyle's steady forward march forced her back. Nadine gave chase, but Emma circled and stayed out of range. Coyle let her frustration show through, reaching out with a lunging right hand to the body. A bad mistake that left her overextended, and Emma punished the error by whacking her in the mouth with the right hand.

They met again near the center of the octagon. Again, both seemed perfectly willing to settle in and trade punches... until Emma started to back out. Coyle saw her opportunity and pushed forward... only for Emma to suddenly plant and start throwing again. Three solid punches found Nadine's midsection without resistance. Coyle tried to respond, but Emma had bounced right back up onto the balls of her feet and skipped away. A perfect hit-and-run.

I was starting to see Emma's plan coming together. Winning a fight at this level is about more than just successfully landing your attacks. You have to lay it all out in a logical sequence. Strategy begets strategy. One thing leads to another.

Step one tonight was running a little bait and switch. Because if there's one thing Nadine loves more than pounding on a helpless opponent, it's beating on fresh meat. She'd left a long line of broken fighters in her wake, and the thought of adding Emma to that collection probably made her mouth water. Knowing this, Emma had dangled herself out there. She'd played Coyle's game, and Nadine had gotten a good, long taste of what it felt like to sink her fists into Emma's young body. But now, Emma had taken it all away. Using her movement and quickness to get her shots in while staying out of reach. Meanwhile, Coyle was practically drooling on the canvas. Craving another bite. She wanted it so badly that she didn't seem to notice they were now playing Emma's game, instead.

The next exchange was even more brief, with Emma retreating almost the minute it started. Coyle followed, and Emma almost immediately stopped to throw another barrage. Nadine tried to respond, but it was like punching into a hailstorm. She had trouble finding her target. By the time she got her bearings, Emma was gone again.

The next meeting was similar. Emma backed up, and Nadine followed. Emma let her come... jabbing and backing slowly across the cage. Letting herself get within a foot of the mesh. Coyle was so close

to trapping her prey for another good pounding that I was sure she was already mapping out the assault. But Emma jabbed and circled and left Nadine with nothing to hit.

Coyle turned to give chase, and Emma seemed happy to let her... jabbing and potshotting her way back across the cage in the other direction. When she got close to the fence, she jabbed and circled. Nadine was more insistent this time - as Emma knew she would be. Coyle side-stepped to cut her off, and Em ripped off the one-two. Strong, accurate punches that forced Nadine to cover up while Emma slid out of harm's way. But she didn't skip away this time. Instead she stayed put and got ready. When Coyle turned to chase, Em was right there waiting.

Left, right.

Two long, straight punches, thrown off the front foot. Less power, but faster to deliver. Coyle ate both before she even realized Emma was there. The Irishwoman tried to jab her off, but Em slipped left and nailed her with the hook. When Coyle finally got herself square and her guard up, she went looking for revenge. But guess what? Emma was already out of range and backing away.

It went like that for over half the round. Emma, in her element, being a fleet-footed pest. Moving and pecking and nicking Coyle up at every turn. Nadine, hungry to dig her knuckles into some flesh, letting Emma lead her around like a dog on a chain.

But things changed again with about two minutes to go. Emma settled down and again became willing to get into the kind of brutal exchanges that had characterized the first round. Probably because she was now winning them with ease. Her hands seemed to be getting faster, which I knew was impossible. The difference was Coyle. She was getting slower. Just as Emma had planned.

Strategy begets strategy. One thing leads to another.

The change in Coyle was obvious. It wasn't just her hands. Everything was slower. Emma's skipping around and guerrilla-style attacks had run her ragged, and now it was Nadine's turn to try to maintain some space. To stay away and give herself the chance to recover.

Emma was having none of it. She was a tiger on the hunt. Patiently stalking and pressuring. Always forward, never back. Herding her prey all around the cage, and letting loose with both hands every time she got her where she wanted her. Stamina was on her side. She was faster than Coyle to begin with, and that advantage now seemed doubled. Nadine couldn't outrun her, and she couldn't get out of the way fast enough when the attacks came. She would try to guard and counter, but this was Emma's show now. She was winning every volley. Landing heavy shots that brought pain and tore at skin. More importantly, each exchange drained Nadine a little bit more. Tipping the scales even further in Emma's direction.

Coyle wasn't getting out of this round. No way.

Em marched on. As methodical as she was brutal. Waiting for her chance to drop the hammer.

It came with twenty seconds to go. Emma came forward again. Tired of running - or maybe unable? - Coyle decided to stand her ground. Emma jabbed. Coyle slipped it and fired back with the right hand, but Emma's technique was flawless and she was thinking of everything. She had very wisely moved her head as she was throwing her punch, and Coyle's response went right into the void she'd left behind. Em put a pair of punches right on Coyle's belly button before Nadine even realized

she'd missed. She tried to recover her guard, but it looked like she was moving underwater compared to Emma. A left hook found Coyle's cheek, followed almost immediately by a right uppercut to the point of her chin.

Coyle's thoughts turned to mush. She scrambled back, shaking her head to clear the cobwebs. She had no idea where she was, and actually backed herself into the fence.

Fifteen seconds to go. The race was on.

Emma surged forward, putting a lunging left into Nadine's gut, followed immediately by the right hand in the same spot. Coyle was a defensive mess. Everything she did was a reaction. Her guard came down and Emma jabbed a left into her nose.

The ten second clacker sounded.

Coyle reached out to try and push her tormentor away. Emma brushed her aside with her right arm, then used her left forearm to jam her back against the cage. Another right hand sunk into Coyle's belly.

Five seconds to go.

C'mon, Em! HIT HER!

Emma recovered her guard, got her feet set, then buried two more punches into Nadine's midsection.

The action halted at the sound of the bell.

So... fucking... close.

Coyle ended the round in exactly the same position as the last one. Crushed against the mesh, with Emma beating the hell out of her. Sanderson was quick to jump in, looking to avoid another fireworks show. Nadine pushed off the fence and straightened up. Emma waited to see if she wanted to start something, but Sanderson's presence kept things cool. Coyle turned and headed for her team. Em followed her with her eyes for a while, then calmly made her way to her own corner.

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The break went pretty much as expected. Emma had gotten through the round pretty cleanly, so Marcy went back to work on the damage from the opener. Steph squared up in front, and dug into strategy. Likely discussing ways to carefully set Coyle up for the finish. Em had let a golden opportunity slip away, but she was way ahead now. Nadine would have to come to her to get back in the fight. There would be more chances.

There was only one slight note of discord. There was a look of concern of Tiffany's face I hadn't noticed earlier, and it troubled me for a moment. No one knows Emma better than Tiff. What was she seeing that the rest of us weren't?

I pushed the thought aside. Dismissed it as the kind of fear you feel when your loved one is risking her body in the cage. The same thing I felt for Danni. Irrational, but implacable.

Emma was dictating and Coyle looked like someone had literally mopped the floor with her. There was nothing to worry about.

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Though Coyle's team had gotten her cleaned up during the break, she was still noticeably sagging as the third round got underway. There was little bounce in her step, and far less fuck you in her battle plan. No more straight ahead like a bull. Now it was circle and keep your distance. For a woman who loved to dish out the pain, she was surprisingly reluctant to engage.

By comparison, Emma was hopping around like a spring chicken. She had good reason to be. Everything was going her way. Not only was she winning, but she looked like a tactical genius. Her odd and risky plan from the opener had paid off, allowing her to turn the second frame into a clinic. Now she had it all in the palm of her hand. Coyle was both desperate and beaten. The only question now was when and how Ms. Watson would get the finish.

Things started off slow. Emma was perfectly willing to match Nadine's circling. The two traded jabs here and there when their orbits brought them within reach of each other, but nothing came of any of it. Not a concern for Emma. All this movement took energy, and she had a lot more of it than her opponent did. On top of that, there was this pervasive sense that Coyle was measuring for something. That her comeback plan boiled down to one big swing, and she was using all this circling to find just the right moment to take it. The odds that something like that would work were small, and Emma was making them smaller by giving her opponent no data to work with.

You show me yours, Nadine... then I'll show you mine.

Coyle didn't make her wait very long... making her move with just over a minute gone. A brief exchange got Emma backing up, with Nadine pressing after her. As they neared the edge of the octagon, Coyle edged right - forcing Emma to circle the same way. Then Nadine slid to her left and slammed the door shut with her jab. Emma guarded it away and got ready. Coyle unleashed a mighty right hook... and hit nothing but air. Emma ducked under and the punch sailed right over the top. She put two more punches into Coyle's gut before standing up to put another pair right into Nadine's face. Then she calmly backed out... completely unscathed.

To me, it was another chance wasted. Nadine was staggered and just about spent. A little crafty footwork would have put her on the fence so Emma could put her away. But it mattered little. Coyle was well on her way. It was just a matter of time.

But Emma seemed to be in no particular hurry. Instead of turning on the pressure, she seemed content to let Coyle drive the action.

Nadine moved back to center. She was a mess. Blood was running from freshly reopened wounds, and she was practically plodding now. Walking straight in with only one thing on her mind. She needed to land that haymaker. A matter of luck and perfect timing... which Emma screwed up by pushing forward at the last second. She landed the one-two. Coyle wound up the right. Emma skipped away. Another hit-and-run. So perfectly executed that Nadine never even got her punch off.

It happened over and over. Nadine stalking around with the right hand locked and loaded. Emma sniping her with fast punches and getting out of there before Coyle could do a damn thing. Twice, Nadine fired off the right despite the fact that she could see she had nothing to hit. Acts of complete frustration and desperation. She was tired and hurting and sick of chasing Emma around. Throwing punches she knew would miss in the hope that she'd get lucky and Emma would do something idiotic.

Fat chance.

Eventually the plodding stopped. To some, this might look like Coyle finally smartening up. After all... if she couldn't hit Emma, there was no point in chasing her. Better to wait. Despite being way ahead, Emma couldn't simply stay away. Sanderson wouldn't allow it. Part of her job was to make sure both fighters continued to engage, which meant Emma would have to come in range and attack from time to time. Coyle would be better off conserving her energy and waiting for those opportunities to come.

The reality was exactly the opposite. Coyle was coming apart in stages, and this was the final one. The last desperate hope.

Yes, Emma would have to engage, but only enough to keep Sanderson off her back. Come in range, fire off a few punches and skitter away. The truth of the matter was that Coyle's odds of success had now dropped to practically zero because she would need Emma to make an even bigger mistake than before.

Again, fat chance.

The action ground to a halt. Despite knowing the ref would eventually get involved, Emma stayed well away from her opponent. For some reason, she wanted Nadine to run some more. Maybe she was hoping Coyle would simply fall down from exhaustion? Regardless, Coyle wasn't playing along.

After a wasted fifteen seconds or so, Sanderson did as she was supposed to and warned both fighters.

Coyle stayed back, hoping Emma would come to her.

Emma stopped dead and made a big show of gesturing for Coyle to come get her.

Coyle still stayed away.

Emma moved only enough to keep Nadine in front of her while gesturing some more. Practically daring Coyle to come after her.

Such theatrics were very unlike her, but apparently she felt Coyle was worthy of a little special treatment.

Sanderson gave another warning.

Emma couldn't have cared less. The worst the ref could do was take away a point from both of them, which would effectively mean nothing. In the meantime, Em was making a point of her own.

Look at this loser... she's afraid to fight me.

And that's exactly what it looked like to every single person watching. They all knew Coyle was the one who needed to fight her way back into this thing, and yet she clearly wasn't interested in doing so.

Emma kept it up, and it was obvious she wasn't going to stop anytime soon.

Just as I was expecting Sanderson to step in again, Nadine suddenly lurched forward.

Maybe she was sick of Emma's taunting. Maybe she thought she would catch Em off-guard and do some damage. But my best guess was that she thought her unexpected surge would surprise Emma enough to force her to scurry away... allowing Coyle to send a silent return message.

Look who's scared now.

Only Emma wasn't scared and she didn't retreat. She stayed right where she was, and once again went toe-to-toe with Nadine Coyle. And beat her every step of the way.

Again, there were two ways to look at the situation. Getting in a firefight with Coyle at this point was a pretty dumb risk to take. On the other hand... it really wasn't any risk at all. Coyle was too far gone to be very dangerous. Her punches were slow, her defense was sloppy and her movement was nearly non-existent. In contrast, Emma had her guard up, her punches were coming in rapid fire bunches, and her head was constantly moving.

The initial exchange was a crazy tangle of limbs, but closer inspection showed Emma was the only one hitting anything. Coyle's first move was to go back to that big right hand. Emma got a pair of body shots in, ducked under the looping right, then landed two more body blows. Coyle tried the left, and got a similar result. Emma hammered her with body shots both before and after the punch, while easily avoiding the blow. Emma slid to her right. Coyle threw another big right as she turned to square up. Emma put two more into her belly, as she slid further right.

After that, it just got stupid. Emma sliding and punching, sliding and punching. Coyle turning to keep up while unloading massive punches. Like watching a deranged gorilla fight off a gnat. If any one of those right hands landed, that would be the end of the fight. But how would one ever land? Emma was much too fast. She was always a step ahead and a mile away by the time the punches came.

This was it. Time for the finish. Pick a spot, maybe use the jab to set her up, then put the vaunted Nadine Coyle out of her misery.

But Emma just kept sliding and punching. Always to the body. Always two shots then move on. Dancing circles around Coyle until she finally got bored with it and changed the sequence. Two to the body, duck the right, two quick, snappy punches to the face and then she circled away.

OK... now, she was just showing off.

None of the punches she'd thrown had been about getting the knockout. You could argue that maybe the repeated body blows were about slowing Coyle down, but seriously... how much slower was she going to get?

No... the whole exchange had been a brutal, extended demonstration. Emma showing everyone how easy this was for her, as she whacked Coyle around the cage like a piñata.

Point made. Message received. No one was going to call her unproven after a performance like this. But the clock said a minute and forty-five seconds to go... which meant it was time to get serious and end this thing.

Emma remained patient. To me, Coyle looked about as dangerous as a box of tissues at this point. So far gone that I think many refs would have stepped in. But she was still on her feet and still coherent, so Sanderson was content to stay out of it. Meanwhile, there was still no reason for Em to take risks... though she'd already taken a whole bunch, so... what was she doing, exactly?

Experienced fighters will tell you that watching a well-planned fight strategy play out is like reading a good story, but I was starting to lose the narrative on this one. All I knew was that we were coming to the end.

The big moment came with about a minute and twenty seconds to go. Emma's patient circling paid off as she was able to cut off the ring and pressure the exhausted Coyle into the mesh. Coyle let loose with a pair of wild punches as she tried to fight her way out of trouble. Emma avoided both and went in for the kill. Two more body shots, a jab to set up the finish... and then a four punch combo to the body, followed by a short, nasty elbow to the face before she circled away.

I didn't get it. I really didn't. All these body shots had more than done their job. Coyle couldn't get any slower without coming to a complete halt. And the elbow was the exact opposite of a knockout blow. It was flashy and unorthodox. Great for speed and surprise when you wanted to throw your opponent off-balance, but that was not what Emma needed. She had already made her point. It was time for her to tidy this one up and call it a day.

I mean... now, she was... just...

Oh, Emma...

Reality dawned on me in sudden fashion, with all the details laid out in front of me like a map.

Emma wasn't missing chances. She was passing them up deliberately.

Prolonging the execution.

Just the way Nadine liked to do.

I'd had it right at the beginning, but read it all wrong. Emma was very interested in righting Nadine's past wrongs, but there had never been any risk of her taking her eye off the ball. She was her usual, confident, thorough self. Totally focused on her goal. I had simply misunderstood what that goal was. This wasn't just about beating Cole. It was about punishing her. Em was seeking vengeance in a way I never would have expected from her... and she was shockingly good at it. She had spent two rounds methodically pounding her opponent into submission, and now she was shoving that ball straight down Nadine Coyle's throat.

Emma went back to circling. It felt much different, now that I understood. I could see the steel in her posture and the challenge in her gaze. But she was content to let time pass, and allow Coyle to make the call. If Nadine wanted to come out and face her, she had plenty left to give. Twice more they skirmished, but Coyle wasn't willing to commit and nothing much came of it. The net-effect was the same as before. Coyle needed to go on the offensive, and she wasn't... because she didn't want to risk having Emma hammer her again. It made her look weak and scared.

With just under twenty seconds to go, Emma took the choice away. She surged forward and bullied Coyle to the fence. What happened after that was not a pretty sight. Emma never really let her hands fly. Everything was short and fast. Quick punches and nasty elbows. Body shots and knees to the midsection. It was an absolute mauling, but there was never any attempt to go for the finish.

The bell found Coyle right back in the same place for the third round in a row. She was much slower to rise this time. Like it took every ounce of effort she had just to get off the fence. She was quite a sight, too. Though no wound was particularly bad, she seemed to have a little blood coming from just about everywhere. Her mouth... her nose... a cut above her right eye... another beneath her left. On top of that, the body shots had taken a heavy toll because she didn't seem to be able to straighten up fully. But the most telling detail was that the vicious and superior Nadine Coyle didn't have a damn thing to say. She didn't even look at Emma before wobbling off to her corner.

But Emma still stood there and watched her go.

* * *

Things in the RSI corner were fairly normal, once again. Emma had commanded the round from bell to bell, so there was very little new damage for Marcy to deal with. As for Steph... as usual, her expression gave away nothing and I really couldn't guess what she was thinking. I highly doubted she could muster any sympathy for Coyle, but I wondered how she felt about Emma being the one doing this to her. Not that it mattered because there was nothing she could do about it. She would once again give advice on how to finish this, but what happened once the bell rang was up to Emma.

As for Tiff... her feelings went unspoken, but that didn't mean they weren't expressed. In-between performing her duties as Marcy's assistant, she spent all her time staring holes in the side of Emma's head. Emma kept her gaze steadily forward... which only proved she felt the stare and understood the message it was meant to convey.

I know what you're doing... and I want you to stop.

I knew what she was doing too, and I didn't know how I felt about it. Part of me wanted Steph or Tiffany or somebody to get in her face. To take her by the shoulders and shake her around until this stupid idea fell out of her head.

But a much darker part of me wanted things a woman in my position isn't supposed to want. That part was a leftover. A shadow of the person I was years ago... when I spent my nights shedding sweat and blood in places that would make Nadine Coyle curl up in a ball and suck her thumb.

There was not one shred of my being that cared about Nadine. She had been earning this for a very long time. So long that I'm sure she thought she was untouchable. That no one would ever dare to try and collect the debt she owed. She probably didn't believe there was anyone who could. Thinking about that put an electric current in my blood. It made me grind my teeth and ball my

hands so tight that my nails dug into my palms. It made me want Em to keep it up. To hit her harder because she hadn't suffered enough. I doubted she ever could... but I knew that she deserved more.

But that did little to fill the cold emptiness in the pit of my stomach. The overwhelming feeling that Emma wasn't the one to do this, and that she was giving up an important piece of herself to make it happen. Not to mention the risk she'd taken, professionally. She had come here with a clear goal: to win this tournament and get that monkey off her back. But she had somehow prioritized making Coyle suffer over that. That didn't fit with the Emma I knew, and I didn't like seeing her this way. I didn't want her to do it any longer.

As it turned out, she wouldn't have to.

Half-way through the break, Coyle's trainer called the ref over. Nadine sat unmoving behind him, and the first clue about what was coming was the relative calm in her corner. With thirty seconds to go and a whole mess to cleanup, her team should have been moving with a sense of urgency that was very obviously missing.

Sanderson exchanged a few words with the trainer. Then she took an extra second to confirm what she'd heard. The trainer nodded.

Still no movement from Coyle.

Sanderson stepped over to the fence to confer with the judges and league officials. The voices from the broadcast feed grew excited. Both of them losing their minds. A murmur rose from the crowd, steadily growing into a roar as everyone in the building realized what was happening.

Nadine Coyle had just quit on her stool.

I turned my eyes back to our corner. Tiffany touched a hand to Emma's back and looked like an enormous weight had just been lifted from her shoulders. Even the usually unreadable Steph seemed to breathe a sigh of relief. But Emma's face showed nothing. No joy. No satisfaction. She just sat there, staring into the center of cage with unseeing eyes.

I knew a little about what she was feeling. I've experienced that moment when the job is done and the stress comes off and you finally get to unpack the reality of what you've done. It never feels the way you expect it to.

Lost in all this was the fact that this was supposed to be Emma's moment. She hadn't simply won the title. She had taken Coyle apart. Beaten her every way you could think of. Couple that with the commanding win over Tiff in the previous round, and there was no longer any doubt that Emma Watson was one of the elite. Anyone who didn't think so was an idiot. But Em didn't seem to be thinking about her hard-won recognition right now. I only hoped she'd find time to enjoy it later.

Sanderson called the fighters to the center for the official decision, but Nadine stayed on her stool and let her team continue to work on her. Most would see that as a display of poor sportsmanship. She was beaten badly, but not severely injured. She owed it to Emma to get off her ass and pay some respect.

I saw it as something else.

Abject humiliation.

Go ahead. Hide in the corner, bitch. It makes no difference. They all saw what Emma did to you.

The announcer's voice cut into my thoughts.

"Ladies AAAAND gentlemen... this fight has been stopped after three rounds due to corner retirement. Your winner by technical knockout and Fall Tournament Featherweight champion... EM-MAAAA WAAAAAAAAAAAAATSONNNN!"

The crowd really let her have it. With her talent and personality, Emma draws a sizable and dedicated fan base. They had been waiting a long time for this, and they were holding nothing back. Whatever fans Nadine had in attendance either joined in or were stone silent. The whole building was celebrating this one. Emma tamped down whatever reservations she had, and gave them the smile on high-beam.

As league officials stepped out to present her with the championship belt, I hopped up and headed for the door.

* * *

With little time and two stops to make, I was basically running through the RSI locker room. I found Trish standing outside one of the training rooms, and correctly assumed she'd just finished with Emma. There was no sign of Marcy, who had probably moved on to getting Danni ready to go.

"How is she?" I asked.

"You don't really want me to answer that."

Not necessarily the thing you want to hear from the team doctor, but I quickly decided I had no real cause for concern. If something serious were wrong, Trish would get right to it. No screwing around. Instead, her tone suggested the only malady she'd found was that Emma was a dumbass. I knew this tone well because she often applies it to me.

"And if I limit my query to only physical ailments?"

She gave me a look like she suspected one dumbass was trying to cover for the other, but let it go at that.

"She'll go through the concussion process like everybody else, but there's no cause for concern."

No surprise there. You get punched in the head, you go through the concussion process. It's automatic. But Trish had found no red flags in the initial screening, which was a very good sign.

"She still in there?"

I suddenly heard shouting coming from the other side of the door.

"Mmm-hmm," Trish answered. "Girlfriend's in there, too."

She took her leave while I stared at the door for a minute. The shouting continued. All of it coming from Tiffany.

Under ordinary circumstances, I would have given them their space. But I still needed to get to Danni before her fight.

I waited for a pause in the rant, then peeked my head in.

"Sorry to intrude," I said, "but I don't have much time."

Emma looked up and said, "Not a problem." Happy for the reprieve.

Tiffany just waved her hand in disgust. Like she knew she'd been wasting her time anyway, so it made no difference.

Marcy and Trish had done their usual excellence with Emma. It probably helped that Em made it easy for them. The first round had been rough, but she hadn't let Coyle do much damage after that. There was some bruising on her face, and she was holding an ice pack to the area below her left eye. That was about it.

"You mind if I steal a minute with her?" I asked Tiffany.

"As long as you're going to tell her how big an idiot she was, too," she snapped back.

I smiled agreeably, but made no such promise.

"That's fine," Tiff continued. "I'm pretty sure she's done listening to me, anyway."

I stepped all the way into the room as she started in the other direction. Then she spun back on Emma.

"Don't go anywhere," she warned. Then she whipped out of the room so fast she actually left a breeze in her wake.

Emma looked at me and said, "I'm in *BIG* trouble."

I shrugged.

"This too shall pass."

"So I take it you didn't come here to yell at me?"

"It seems Tiff has that angle covered," I said, "but, just so we're on the same page, you're definitely an idiot."

She nodded in passive agreement.

"You're also kind of a badass," I added.

Her eyes flicked to me, and a hint of a smile played at the corners of her mouth. But it was too soon. The weight of what she'd done was still right on top of her.

"How do you feel?" I asked.

"I'm fine. She barely touched me."

I guess she thought maybe I missed that opening round.

"I'm not talking about physically."

There was a long pause while she composed her response. The pause told me more than she did.

"I feel alright."

"Feel as good as you thought it would?"

Another pause.

"No."

"It never does."

She eyed me suspiciously.

"You seem to know a lot about this."

"I do," I said. "I also know vengeance is never free. It costs you something to go out there and get it the way you did."

She nodded again.

"Still feels pretty good though," I added.

Her little smirk appeared.

"Especially in the moment," she said.

We both took a minute to appreciate that. Because it does feel good, and anyone who says it isn't worth it is a liar.

But the price still had to be reckoned with.

"I don't know what made you decide you were the one to do this," I said, "but don't waste a lot of time on it. She deserved it, and you gave it to her. Nothing to feel bad about."

"Still hurts, though."

"It should hurt," I said. "This was work for you. Ugly work that needed to be done. But you're not like her, and you never will be. That's why it hurts."

We held on each other for a long time because I wanted to make sure she understood.

Then I decided on a little test.

"Gotta wonder about Nadine, though," I said. "She might be looking to get even."

Emma shook her head.

"She had me in the cage. If she wanted it, she could have gotten it right there," she said coldly. "She quit instead."

I smiled and mentally checked the box to indicate the test had been passed.

Clearly, she felt bad, but not too bad. She had given Coyle what she deserved. And if Nadine came looking for revenge... well then she'd just do it again.

"I gotta go," I said, "but if you feel this coming back on you, you know where to find me. And don't worry about Tiff. You scared her, and you're gonna have to pay for that. But deep down, she agrees with what you did."

"How do you know?"

"Because we all agree with what you did."

She gave the little smile again, then it grew another inch or two. In a way that felt totally genuine. Like the ice that had been flowing through her veins a little while ago was starting to thaw.

Then she nodded and said, "Tell Danni to kick ass."